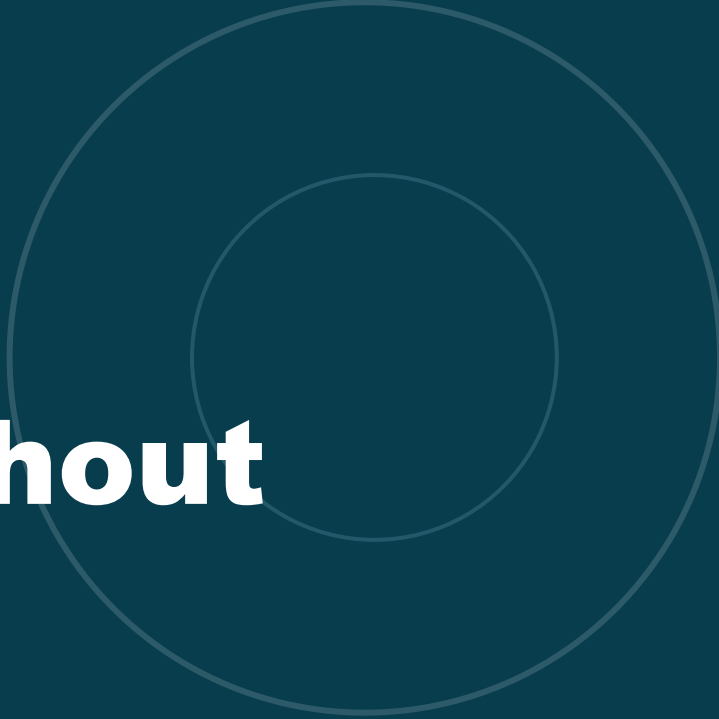




Giving Without Knowing

How Major Donors Navigate Political Giving They Cannot Measure

Prepared for Majority Rising NC

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Table of Contents

Executive Summary.....	3
Introduction.....	4
The Landscape: More Money, Less Visibility.....	5
Research and Analysis Plan.....	10
Findings: How Donors Give Without Knowing.....	12
Recommendations for MRNC.....	25
Conclusion.....	28
Appendices and Supporting Materials.....	29
Axis 1: Information Sources.....	33
Axis 2: Evaluation Criteria.....	33
Axis 3: Allocation Logic.....	34
Axis 4: Relationships.....	36
Cross-cutting tags.....	37

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Executive Summary

Nearly \$15 billion was spent on the 2024 presidential and congressional elections, moving through near-record numbers of committees, more kinds of giving vehicles, and less-visible channels than at almost any point in American history. This report asks how the high-net-worth individuals (HNIs) supplying much of that money decide where it goes, and what their decision-making means for Majority Rising NC (MRNC), a North Carolina 501(c)(4) competing for their support.

After 36 semi-structured interviews (25 major donors, 11 professional donor advisors), the central finding is that major donors have rationally adapted to a question that cannot be answered. The information a rigorous evaluation would require, such as whether a gift will matter or how the money will be spent, was described by most donors as unknowable in advance. Rather than guess, they have built practical systems. They decide in advance through rules that settle most asks before any deliberation is needed (92% of donors). They delegate judgment to people and institutions they trust (56%). And they size their giving based on confidence in the candidate or cause, letting the amount, not the yes-or-no, carry the decision (52%). The systems are real, and they bend at one predictable point: relationships. Roughly two-thirds of donors described exceptions to their rules made for people they know, and most named the pattern themselves. 84% acknowledged some gap between their stated criteria and their actual giving. The same relational logic governs how donors choose to end their giving. In every instance where donors described ending their support for an institution or candidate, it never followed an election loss. It did, however, follow a leadership change, a lapse of stewardship, the conduct of the people involved, an ideological shift.

Donors cluster into four types: Strategists, Planners, Loyalists, and Responders. Most donors blend elements of more than one, however. And their advisors form a near-perfect professional mirror, sourcing giving opportunities where donors receive and researching where donors delegate.

Six recommendations follow: become the filter donors already trust; serve both donors who trust systems and donors who trust people; show donors what their money did; show them why their dollars matter; protect the relationships that hold the money; and deliver the asks that matter through key voices donors already trust.

Introduction

American political money now moves through more channels, and more kinds of vehicles, than at any point in the country's history.¹ The nearly \$15 billion spent on the 2024 presidential and congressional elections² is only the federal ledger; in addition, vast sums of money moved through state races, including North Carolina's.

More money than ever is moving. Active federal campaign committees grew from roughly 6,600 in the 2001–02 cycle to a peak of nearly 12,000 in 2021–22, an increase of 80% (Figure 1). In North Carolina, active committees nearly doubled over the same period.

The landscape that money moves through is also more complex than ever. A donor today faces a menu of giving vehicles, the legal entities through which political money can flow: candidate committees, party committees, traditional PACs, super PACs, 501(c)(4) social welfare groups, and 501(c)(3) charitable organizations that do nonpartisan civic engagement work, each with different contribution rules, disclosure requirements, and theories of change (Table 1). And the money moving through the least-visible vehicles has spiked since 2010, a shift this report returns to below.

For the donor, the result is a demanding environment. Appeals arrive daily, sometimes hourly. The entities behind them span the ideological spectrum and compete fiercely to argue that their approach is the most effective way to seek change in government, or to defend against changes the donor opposes. Donors who stay engaged end up doing a strategist's job without a strategist's information: weighing the benefits of allocating their funds to one entity over another under a high level of uncertainty. This stands contrary to other marketplaces in the private sector where numerous metrics exist for evaluation. In the private sector, the cost of misallocating resources bears out in personal, private loss. The misallocation of political resources weakens the causes the donor set out to advance.

As competition for political resources intensifies, organizations must understand how donors decide where to invest their next dollar. Majority Rising NC (MRNC) is a 501(c)(4) social welfare organization based in North Carolina whose mission is building majority support for public policies that bring prosperity and opportunity to all North Carolinians.³ As a social welfare organization it can and does engage in political causes, legislative accountability, and issue advocacy. To resource its work, MRNC must attract, retain, and deploy the support of major donors operating in this complex and information-scarce environment.

These conditions raise the project's central question at the core of this project: **How do high-net-worth individuals (HNIs) evaluate political giving opportunities under conditions of uncertainty and constraint, and what decision-making frameworks shape how they allocate resources across political organizations?** This question directly advances MRNC's mission by generating a more rigorous understanding of how major donors make giving decisions. The findings are intended to inform two of the organization's strategic priorities: ensuring its long-term sustainability and strengthening the broader civic infrastructure of the state. A clearer picture of donor decision-making will help MRNC refine its value proposition, structure its donor relationships, and position itself as a trustworthy intermediary capable of reducing the information gaps that constrain strategic political giving.

The Landscape: More Money, Less Visibility

Two decades of legal change reshaped political giving

The modern political giving environment is the product of a two-decade legal transformation. The Bipartisan Campaign Reform Act of 2002 (BCRA), known as McCain–Feingold, was designed to curb corruption by restricting soft money, the unlimited contributions that had flowed to parties outside the federal limits. Its mixed legacy includes weakening traditional party committees relative to newer, more decentralized vehicles.⁴ The Supreme Court's *Citizens United* decision (2010) removed limits on independent political spending by corporations and unions,⁵ and months later *SpeechNow.org v. FEC* paved the way for super PACs, which may raise and spend unlimited sums so long as they do not coordinate with candidates.⁶ Together these changes opened wide lanes for political money outside the comparatively transparent, limit-bound party system.

Today's donor can allocate across that full menu. Table 1 summarizes the major vehicle types and the tradeoffs each presents.

Table 1. A taxonomy of political giving vehicles (underlying committee data in Appendix A)

Vehicle	What it does	Tax status	Contribution limits	Donor disclosure
Candidate committee	Elects a specific candidate	527	Limited (federal caps; state caps vary)	Public

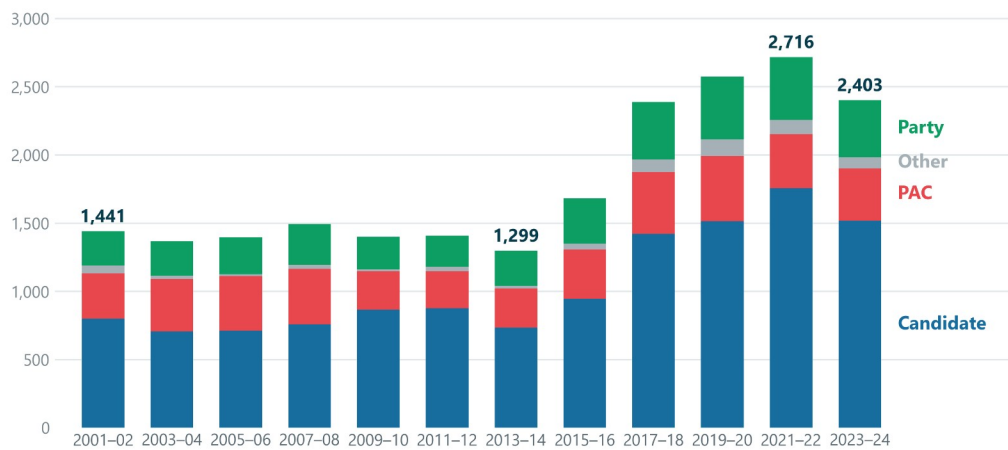
Vehicle	What it does	Tax status	Contribution limits	Donor disclosure
Party committee	Supports the party's slate and infrastructure	527	Limited federally (higher caps); some states, including North Carolina, allow unlimited gifts to state parties ¹	Public
Traditional PAC	Pools contributions; gives directly to candidates	527	Limited (federal caps; state caps vary)	Public
Super PAC	Unlimited independent spending; no coordination with candidates	527	Unlimited	Public
501(c)(4) social welfare organization	Issue advocacy and some political activity (not its primary purpose)	501(c)(4)	Unlimited	Generally not disclosed
501(c)(3) charitable organization	Cannot engage in campaign politics, but funds civic infrastructure adjacent to it	501(c)(3)	Unlimited (tax-deductible)	Generally not disclosed

A 501(c)(4) such as MRNC therefore competes for donor dollars against traditional targets, candidates, parties, and PACs, as well as newer entities, while offering a distinct profile: flexibility and donor privacy, at the cost of the public accountability signals the older vehicles carry.

¹ In *National Republican Senatorial Committee v. Federal Election Commission*, No. 24-621 (U.S. June 30, 2026), the Supreme Court struck down, 6 to 3, the federal limits on coordinated party expenditures, the caps on what parties may spend in coordination with their own candidates, overruling *FEC v. Colorado Republican Federal Campaign Committee* (2001). Contribution limits on gifts to parties still apply, but a party may now spend those funds in full coordination with its candidates, which materially raises what the party channel can do with a donor's money.

Active campaign committees in North Carolina by election cycle, 2001–2024

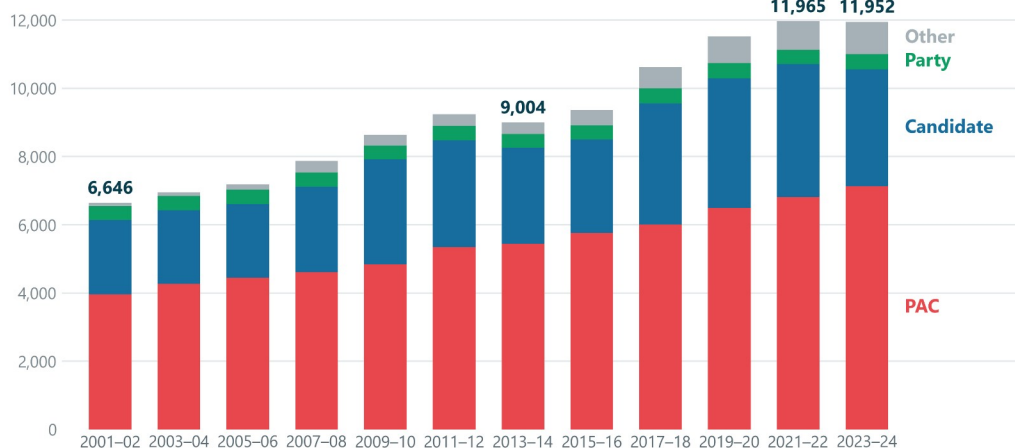
Committees with a recorded receipt or expenditure in the cycle, by type. Flat near 1,400 through 2013–14, then nearly doubling by 2021–22.



NC State Board of Elections disclosure data, through the last complete cycle (2023–24). Restricting to committees raising new money from original sources gives ~77% of each count with the same trajectory (see data table).

Active federal campaign committees by election cycle, 2001–2024

Committees with at least one receipt or disbursement in the cycle, by type. Up 80% since 2001–02, led by PAC growth.



FEC bulk committee summary files (2007–08 onward); earlier cycles from FEC candidate summary files and committee totals data. Through the last complete cycle (2023–24). Candidate counts for 2001–06 are candidate-level and understate committee counts by about 6%. Joint fundraising committees are counted in Other.

Figure 1. Active campaign committees per election cycle, North Carolina (top) and federal (bottom), 2001–2024. Author's analysis of NCSBE disclosure data and FEC bulk and API data; full data tables in Appendix A.

What has changed most is the money and where it goes. Spending through the least-visible vehicles has spiked since *Citizens United*. Reported election spending by groups that are not political committees, mostly 501(c)(4)s and (c)(6)s that do not disclose their donors, jumped from \$153 million in 2009–10 to a \$319 million peak in 2011–12, before undisclosed money increasingly shifted into super PAC contributions and unreported issue advertising. North Carolina saw the transformation at close range. In 2001–02, five outside

groups reported a combined \$57,000 in the state's elections. In each recent cycle, roughly one hundred non-candidate, non-party groups spent between \$25 million and \$59 million.

Meanwhile, visibility has moved in the opposite direction. The Brennan Center's *Secret Spending in the States* documents that fully transparent outside spending in surveyed states fell from 76% in 2006 to 29% in 2014.⁷ More money, less information. The demanding environment donors describe in this study's interviews is the predictable product of exactly these trends.

What current research says about how donors behave

The empirical literature has converged on findings this project extends or tests. The political scientist Adam Bonica, who maps the donor universe by ideology, finds a marketplace in which donors mostly fund the candidates and committees closest to their own politics.⁸ These studies suggest donors behave expressively, but they infer motive from contribution records, not from donors' own accounts. Michael Barber's research on state contribution limits shows that different vehicles attract different donor types, with individual donors giving expressively, for values and identity, and PACs giving transactionally, for access and results,⁹ and subsequent work argues that rules disadvantaging parties have shifted money toward more ideological vehicles, with measurable consequences for polarization.¹⁰ For this project, the implication is that vehicle choice encodes donor strategy. The long-standing investor–ideologue–intimate typology remains the reference framework for donor motivation,¹¹ though the entity landscape it was built against has changed dramatically, a gap this project's own donor typology addresses. And survey research documents real differences in donor preferences, a warning against assuming major donors want the same things from their giving.¹²

The parallel literature on elite philanthropy sharpens the picture. Interview-based work frames elite giving as a culturally embedded practice tied to identity and status as much as to any concrete return the money buys,¹³ and treats the donor's relationship to wealth itself as an analytical object.¹⁴ The Bank of America/Lilly Family School study, the longest-running empirical window into affluent giving, finds that a majority of wealthy donors report no giving strategy at all, and only one in five monitor or evaluate the impact of their giving.¹⁵ Scholars have also documented donors increasingly channeling resources through coordinated intermediaries that perform vetting and portfolio construction on their behalf,¹⁶ with the same pull toward intermediary structures visible in the charitable sector.¹⁷ These studies predict the tension this project examines: donors who describe

strategy but often lack the information, or the process, to enact it, and intermediaries stepping into that gap.

North Carolina: The Quintessential Swing State

For decades, North Carolina has perplexed the nation with its politics. The state's governor remains one party while the state's legislature holds majorities of the other party. Veteran North Carolina journalist Rob Christensen attempted to disentangle the vexing state's affairs in his 2008 book *The Paradox of Tar Heel Politics*,¹⁸ and Christopher Cooper, Professor of Political Science at Western Carolina University, took his own crack at the phenomenon in his 2024 book *Anatomy of a Purple State*,¹⁹ identifying three trends consistently at play: nationalization, competition, and polarization. Recent scholarship on state politics supplies the structural context. As Congress has gridlocked, resources have shifted to the states, with national donor networks becoming primary engines translating money into durable state-level policy outcomes.²⁰ The state's competitive gubernatorial, legislative, and judicial races, alongside Republican legislative majorities operating against statewide Democratic wins, make strategic giving both consequential and observable. The committee data bear this out. Active North Carolina committees rose from roughly 1,400 per cycle through 2013–14 to a peak of 2,716 in 2021–22 (Figure 1).

Where this project fits

Two identifiable gaps in the literature frame how this project will contribute to the work.

First, political giving has an information problem. Joseph Stiglitz's work on information asymmetry explains how markets behave when one party knows substantially more than the other.²¹ Two of that literature's central issues map directly onto political giving: **adverse selection**, in which donors who cannot tell strong organizations from weak ones end up funding the best marketers rather than the best operators, and **moral hazard**, in which recipients who know they will not be audited face little discipline on how the money is actually used. Nonprofit scholars have applied the lens to charitable trust and monitoring, and legal scholars address information problems from the voter's and public's side.²² The donor's side, a major donor confronting an organization whose strategy and effectiveness they can observe only imperfectly, has not been systematically examined. This project applies information-asymmetry analysis directly to donor decision-making, across vehicles that differ in disclosure, leverage, and credibility.

Second, political giving has a portfolio problem. Donors spread money across many vehicles, which naturally invites the language of investment portfolios. In finance, portfolio theory as developed by Harry Markowitz is the discipline of allocating across assets by weighing each one's expected return and risk against the others, so the whole holds up even when single bets fail.²³ The catch is that reliable estimates of likely outcomes are required and political giving cannot supply them. There is no agreed measure of a political return, and no way to price the odds. The portfolio frame is useful because it cannot be executed and it sharpens the question of what donors actually do in place of the optimization they cannot perform.

This project asks the people the frameworks are meant to describe (major donors and their advisors) how they decide. Its value lies in applying well-developed frameworks to a setting where they have not been systematically tested or grounded in qualitative evidence.

Research and Analysis Plan

The project relied on semi-structured interviews with HNIs and donor advisors as well as publicly available campaign finance data from the FEC and NCSBE used to establish the aggregate landscape.

The interviews

In just over two months, 36 semi-structured interviews were conducted, 25 with HNIs and 11 with donor advisors. Thirteen of the 36 came from outside the researcher's own network, and 72% of the donors were anchored in North Carolina. Interviews were recorded and transcribed with participant consent using Granola, an enterprise transcription service. Four participants preferred not to be recorded and so the researcher captured the conversation in detailed typed notes. The notes informed the pattern analysis but were never used for verbatim quotation. Interview protocols are in Appendix B (Tables B1–B2).

Table 2. Interview Sample Composition (n=36)

Interview Type	North Carolina	National	Total
HNI (Donors)	18	7	25
Donor Advisors	2	9	11

Interview Type	North Carolina	National	Total
Total	20	16	36

The advisor group included nine paid donor advisors and two practitioner leaders of organizations who play advisory roles for major donors. For simplicity, this report calls them advisors throughout.

How the interviews were analyzed

Transcripts were coded against a structured codebook organized around four analytical axes, each answering one question about a giving decision:

Table 3. The four analytical axes (full codebook in Appendix C)

Axis	The question it answers	Example codes
Information sources	How does an opportunity reach the donor?	direct personal ask; mass-channel screening; intermediary briefing
Evaluation criteria	How is an opportunity judged?	viability screen; marginal-dollar test; candidate quality; named unknowables
Allocation logic	How is money distributed?	standing rules; gift sizing; vehicle choice
Role of relationships	Who shapes the decision?	delegated vetting; relationship overrides; person-trust

Two cross-cutting tags were applied alongside the axis codes: *negative case* (refusals, exits, and counter-examples, treated as findings rather than noise) and *stated-versus-enacted* (applied only where a subject named a divergence between their stated rules and their actual giving themselves). Throughout this report, an "exit" means a donor ending their support for an organization or candidate they previously funded.

The analysis proceeded in three stages. First, the researcher read and annotated the transcripts and drafted a preliminary codebook with initial findings. Second, a systematic process of anonymization across every transcript occurred manually. This included removing names and personally identifiable information (PII). Third, following the anonymization and with the consultation of the faculty advisor and graduate program director, an air-gapped environment was staged to create a parallel AI-coded codebook (Claude Code by Anthropic) meaning no interview data could leave the researcher's machine. With heavy direction by the researcher, a 22-code codebook was formulated

across all 36 anonymized transcripts. A separate quantitative screen in R, built by translating the 20 codebook codes into keyword dictionaries and running them across the raw transcript text of the 28 cleanly segmented interviews, recovered the codebook's anchor passages for 15 of the 20 codes. Every verbatim quote was sent to its participant for approval and their own revisions were adopted where offered. Quotes without an approval were paraphrased.

Finally, two disclosed limitations are important to hold. First, the codebook was developed from these interviews, so applying it back to the same interviews partly tests the instrument on the data that built it. The R layer is a screening check rather than a true independent validation. The cleaner answer to this issue is coding a future held-out interview against the locked codebook, identified as a next step for this work. Second, the researcher is professionally connected to the intermediary landscape studied here. In seven donor interviews, the intermediary the subject praised is connected to the researcher's own network. Those interviews are read with that in mind, and no finding rests solely on them.

Findings: How Donors Give Without Knowing

Eight recurring patterns emerged across the 36 donor and advisor interviews (a pattern is counted once per interview in which it appears; see Appendix C). Together, these findings describe how donors respond to the uncertainty identified in the research question, and they tell a connected story in three parts. First, the information donors want before giving cannot generally be known, so donors have built ways to give without it. This includes delegating judgment to people they trust and letting the size of the gift carry their confidence. Second, most allocation is decided in advance by self-imposed rules, and where the rules bend, they bend toward relationships. Third, donors themselves recognize the distance between the criteria they describe and the giving they do. That candor is the most consistently self-reported pattern in these interviews.

What the coding found

Code prevalence by role shown by share of interviews in which each code fires at least once by axis family. Sorted by donor prevalence within family.



Figure 2. Prevalence of each coded pattern among donors (n=25) and advisors (n=11), grouped by analytical axis. Interview-level presence counts; see Appendix C for code definitions.

Part I. Giving without knowing

Finding 1: The information donors want cannot be known in advance, and donors give anyway.

Near the end of each interview, donors were asked what they most wanted to know before making a gift. Of the 25 donors, 15 (60%), along with 8 of 11 advisors, named information that cannot realistically be known in advance: whether the candidate will win, how the money is actually spent, what the real need for the next dollar is, whether the candidate will follow through in office, and whether some hidden problem is waiting to surface. What unites these answers is that none can be verified when a gift is made. A common refrain was that they could not know whether their contribution would ultimately make a difference, and that they had accepted this while continuing to give. One donor wished aloud for the impossible product, "I wish I had consumer reports for the groups I give to... what is their impact and how well do they work with other groups?" (Interview 25). Another donor asked what he would most want to see before giving, "What are you spending it on specifically?" because "you don't get any visibility when you give to a candidate. Not really" (Interview 31). A third closed the interview by turning the research question back on the researcher, "So if you could tell me the correct way to give. That's most effective. I'd appreciate it" (Interview 15).

In place of the information they cannot have, donors substitute observable signals. These signs can be a thank-you note as evidence of stewardship, the visible effort of a candidate who keeps calling as proof of how hard they would work if elected, the names of who else is giving as evidence of quality. One donor's appreciation test is exactly that, "if a candidate sends me a form letter with his name or her name stamped as a signature — don't come back," while a two-page handwritten note from [a member of Congress the donor supports] passes even when "I usually can't read it, but the thought is there" (Interview 04). Another donor learned to trust an organization because "people who I trusted, trust this organization... people that maybe had less to give than me were still giving" (Interview 03). Donors know these signals are thin and they treat them as the best available evidence. As one put it, "whatever candidates savvy enough to get me on the phone or catch me face to face are the ones I give to" (Interview 31).

The information gap changes behavior in both directions, moving money toward organizations that show their work and holding it back from those that do not. One donor redirected giving toward an organization over candidates specifically because it showed where the money was used. Another donor mostly withholds from the grassroots groups

she believes are most effective because she can only know them secondhand. The doubt can be blunt even toward causes a donor actively funds. One donor described her reaction to a Senate campaign she supports, "I appreciate what you're doing. But — do you have a clue?" (Interview 05). The exceptions are suggestive too. Three donors reported no felt information gap, and the two whose interviews explore it most fully were both unusually close to their local political worlds, near enough to the candidates and organizations they fund to observe directly what other donors can only infer. The gap disappears where firsthand observation replaces inference. This is consistent with the gap being a real information problem rather than a manner of speaking.

This finding could simply be read as a demand curve. What donors describe wanting, such as spending visibility, or marginal need, amounts to unmet demand for credible reporting on impact, a point the recommendations return to. But the finding itself must be stated carefully. Donors did not merely say the information is hard to get. They said it cannot be known in advance, and they give at scale anyway. That establishes the premise of this entire study from the subjects' own accounts. If the information were obtainable, the trust and the gift-sizing described below would not need to exist. That would turn the standing rules into a solo job of managing the overwhelming volume of asks.

Finding 2: Donors resolve information gaps through trusted relationships.

Faced with judgments they cannot make, most donors do not do more research. Only 36% of donors (9 of 25) describe first-person diligence such as reading routines, records research, or formal evaluation as a regular practice. Instead, 56% (14 of 25) transfer the evaluative work to someone they trust. This could be a friend, a family member, professional advisors, campaign staff, or independent political commentators. The clearest demonstration of how much weight a single trusted judgment can carry came from one donor's account, "[a former statewide officeholder] told me she thought [the other party's candidate] was the better candidate...I normally might have given him a little something," and on that private word alone, gave nothing (Interview 09). The same pattern shows up from the supply side. All eleven advisors describe providing exactly this vetting service (Finding 8). In effect, the delegating donor stops evaluating races, which are many, continuous, and unknowable, and instead evaluates the intermediary. This becomes a feasible, one-time decision made only occasionally.

The donors who delegate can explain the practice. One stated the reallocation of effort precisely, "I'm much more dependent on... a trusted intermediary... so I'm trying to evaluate

my third party intermediaries more than I am the candidate" (Interview 02). Another gives to an intermediary organization because its vetting is the thing of value being bought, "the reason I give [an organization] money is because it's targeted... I figure [the organization has] done the homework... [the organization has] vetted the candidates" (Interview 12). Another directs her single largest gift through the same logic, "I don't even look to [the organization] to know who to give to... I write [the organization] my biggest check. Because I'll know [the organization will] give it where it's most effective" (Interview 05).

**"I'm much more dependent on... a trusted
intermediary... so I'm trying to evaluate my third party
intermediaries more than I am the candidate"**

– A donor describing the evaluative work of delegating judgment

One pattern seen in reading the transcripts but not coded explicitly is that donors seem to delegate to different kinds of trust. Some trust an institution that offer transparent screens and slates with the reasoning attached. Others trust people where a known individual whose judgment alone is enough. If that split is real, a strategy built for one kind of donor may not serve the other. It is worth testing this directly with donors. What the coding does establish is delegation has its bounds. A minority of donors, including some of the most systematic donors interviewed, refuse it entirely, treating any intermediary's judgment as a substitute they do not want. Delegation in this sample is selective and actively chosen, not a default.

Finding 3: Confidence sets the size of the gift, not whether it is given.

For roughly half the donors (13 of 25), deciding whether to give is seen as a foregone conclusion. The amount is where the real decision happens. Doubt does not block these donors from giving, and it does not send them off to do research either. It discounts the size of the gift. Donors described small gifts where they knew little or felt obligated where the real money is reserved for genuine priorities. The cleanest statement of this behavior came from a donor asked how she gets comfortable giving without the information he wants, "Well, I probably give less if I have no idea. I mean, okay, \$500, whatever — I can do that,

and it could be a mistake and I'm not going to spend a lot of time worrying about it" (Interview 28). In one interview, the donor and their spouse walk through a deliberate spectrum, "I gave \$500 to [a heavily favored candidate]. I knew she didn't need much... I gave \$2,500 to [a candidate facing a primary]," and, as a standing rule, "if it's a real close race, I tend to give more" (Interview 09).

Sizing does double duty. The same move that absorbs uncertainty also manages social pressure. When a friend asks and the answer should probably be no, the check shrinks instead. And when donors describe the mechanism failing, it most often fails toward giving too much rather than giving too little. For anyone studying donor behavior, this finding carries a practical lesson that the evaluation lives within the size of a check. An analysis that only asks whether a donor gave will conclude that little evaluation is occurring, and it will be looking in the wrong place.

Part II. Rules govern, until relationships intervene

Finding 4: Donors allocate by standing rules, but relationships upend them.

Most of what looks like evaluation has already happened before any ask arrives. 92% of donors (23 of 25) described self-imposed standing rules that allocate giving in advance. This includes geographic boundaries, party defaults, fixed dollar tiers by office, annual or per-cycle budgets, and, in the most developed cases, a single stated objective that every gift must serve. The rules do two jobs. First, they manage an ask volume donors experience as overwhelming, and, second, they supply a socially acceptable refusal. One donor keeps an in-state-only rule, "This is my metric. I can't give to everybody... if there's 10 competitive races, then I'll kind of think in my head, well, that's \$10,000... right now I don't give to anybody outside the state of North Carolina" (Interview 16). The rule doubles as a refusal script for out-of-state causes or candidates, "I just say — literally say — appreciate your service and your willingness to run so much, but we have so many competitive races in North Carolina" (Interview 16). Another donor describes the guidelines as a guardrail against a real hazard, "I could go broke in one cycle. Easy... I had to put in rules to stop that from happening" (Interview 20).

The rules work. Nearly a third of the full sample (including three advisors) narrates no specific refusal anywhere, no named opportunity they turned down, and the most consistent reading is that the rules settle most asks before a refusal is ever needed. This is good evidence that the rules are doing real work rather than serving as self-description. That said, the interview structure may fail to surface refusals that happened.

But the rules bend, and they bend toward relationships. 64% of donors (16 of 25) describe relationship-driven exceptions, and most name the pattern themselves. One donor, scrolling his own donation records aloud during the interview, produced a run of exceptions and delivered the verdict without prompting, "So, yeah, there's a lot of exceptions," which, he explained, "usually fall into some sort of event that either sounds really fun or is a particularly good networking event" (Interview 20). Another stated a rule and reversed it inside a single sentence, "If [someone from the other party] calls me, I'm not going to — well, that's not true. There are a few... one that's a judge. He's a longtime friend and he does really good job. But usually party affiliation, you know, rule it out" (Interview 31). A third stated a rule against federal giving, "I pretty much written off giving... federal dollars... although I have given some money in some house races," and then described the exception underway for a personal friend's federal campaign (Interview 12). When a rule meets a relationship, donors rarely refuse outright and rarely give the total ask. They manage the collision of their rules through Finding 3's mechanism. The gift shrinks to a small amount that honors the relationship without abandoning the framework. "If a friend asks me to give and I don't think it's a good candidate, I give \$250" (Interview 10). Cases exist at both ends. One donor reports no standing budget or plan for political giving at all, by his own contrast with his structured charitable giving (Interview 11), and another argues the discipline would backfire, "I think I would probably give less if I had a budget" (Interview 16). But the typical donor holds rules and exceptions together.

"If a friend asks me to give and I don't think it's a good candidate, I give \$250"

— A donor sharing how standing rules bend for relationships

One further evaluation rule deserves its own mention, because the research literature largely misses it. 80% of donors (20 of 25) ask not "can this candidate win?" but "does my gift matter?", steering money away from races saturated with cash and toward places where dollars are scarce. Early money, down-ballot races, less-crowded states, and close margins tend to fit this pattern. One donor declines to fund an incumbent he believes in and knows personally, at a scale where his check disappears, "You believe in them, but it's such a small little drop in the ocean" (Interview 14). Another applies the same arithmetic and

repurposes the check entirely, "even the max... isn't tilting any of these races... that's just not really relevant to me. At my level." His giving, he says, is "mostly for the networking and the meeting people" (Interview 20). This is the closest behavior in the sample to genuine portfolio thinking, leverage per dollar, and it operates as a standing rule rather than a per-race calculation.

Finding 5: Trust stays with people, not institutions.

Among donors who narrated the histories of their giving relationships, loyalty stayed with people. That loyalty could be to a staffer, a board member, a volunteer fundraiser, an aligned candidate. It rarely stayed with the organizations those people work in. The pattern is clearest and one-sided in how giving ends. Narrated exits appear in six interviews in this study, and every exit followed a failure inside the organization, whether a leadership departure, board drift, staff bloat, misconduct, or an unacknowledged gift. One donor ended support for a national party committee over its leadership and separately declined a state-level committee outright upon learning the size of its staff relative to its fundraising target (Interview 04). Another described a candidate's fall after firsthand reports of his conduct, "[the candidate] went from someone who I had hosted a fundraiser in my home for — to dead to me politically" (Interview 22). A third donor, despite a long-standing leadership role in party fundraising, is currently withholding support over concerns about the organization's direction (Interview 21).

"[the candidate] went from someone who I had hosted
a fundraiser in my home for — to dead to me
politically"

— A donor declining further support after firsthand reports of a candidate's
conduct

None of the narrated exits followed an electoral loss. The interviews did not systematically probe exits so this is a pattern in the departures donors chose to describe. But its one-sidedness across every available case is notable, and donors' patience with losing is its own evidence, "of course I want them to win, but whether or not they win rarely impacts the

donation... 50 years will make you a little jaded. I've come to realize it's about the fight as much as it is the victory" (Interview 17).

As institutions, political parties do not hold the same donor loyalty either. Party giving in this sample runs on loyalty and identity as a standing default, and even it is not immune to people, as when one trusted person's private word reversed a gift the donor would otherwise have made on party loyalty. Institutional attachment in this sample is either a standing rule or a relationship dressed in an institution's name.

Donor relationships that live in a single staffer or founder are contingent on that person's tenure. A successor may inherit the role, but the trust does not follow. This pattern makes fundraising fragile across staff transitions, and unlike most findings in this study, it points to factors squarely within an organization's control. Those strategies can include acknowledgment discipline or leadership-transition planning.

Part III. What donors say, what donors do, and who they are

Finding 6: Donors put viability first in words and set it aside in practice.

The most frequently stated evaluation criterion in the sample is viability. 72% of donors (18 of 25) say a race must be winnable to merit a gift. It is also the most routinely overridden criterion in the sample, and the overrides are usually deliberate. Some donors are focused on building the candidate bench, "I definitely give in races where I know it's a long shot... even in races where I know somebody's going to lose. Because I think it helps. I'm really concerned about building up a bench and encouraging people to run in future years" (Interview 10). Some are executing a multi-cycle strategy. One donor put it plainly, "I actually frankly thought that [the candidate] had no chance of winning. Period... But I thought it was a worthwhile effort" (Interview 19). And sometimes the contradiction lives front and center. Asked the one thing he wishes he could know before giving, one donor answered, "Are we going to win?" and moments later, "Of course I want them to win, but whether or not they win rarely impacts the donation" (Interview 17).

The say-do gap runs far beyond electoral viability, and its most important property is that donors report it themselves. 84% of donors (21 of 25) named at least one divergence between their stated rules and their actual giving. Every one of these was volunteered by the donor. Several disclaim their own stated systems outright. One donor, after forty minutes of strategy talk, offered the caution himself, "one always tries to make one sound better. And hindsight is 20/20 on why you did x or y... A lot of this is more impulsive... I

don't want to make it sound as if I'm as intellectually consistent or really strategic when I might just say, oh screw it" (Interview 19). Another named the gap before it happened, describing the criterion she wishes governed and the one she predicts will, "I really want to say whose race is more crucial right now? And I want that to be true, but I also know that it would come down to... the relationship with who was making the ask" (Interview 03).

Advisors see the same thing from the supply side. Asked how most donors decide what to support, one advisor's answer was blunt that the charisma of the leader and the quality of the story, with or without evidence, drives a decision because most people are not looking for evidence. Another described advocating a cause to a client for months without effect, "and then, I don't know, [a cable-news host] talks about it or something, and then all of a sudden it's like — what do we do about this?" (Advisor interview 06). The same advisor put the sharpest point on charisma, "A lot of elected officials, a lot of candidates are boring as hell... But they know how to win" (Advisor interview 06). Donors describe this pattern in themselves. Advisors, serving a partly different and generally wealthier clientele, describe the same pattern in their clients. Taken together, these findings suggest that stated decision criteria are relatively weak predictors of actual giving behavior, and that anyone studying donors should weight what they do over what they say governs them.

**"A lot of elected officials, a lot of candidates are boring
as hell... But they know how to win"**

— A donor advisor on their clients' chase for inspiration

The self-named say-do gap

Share naming at least one divergence between stated criteria and enacted giving

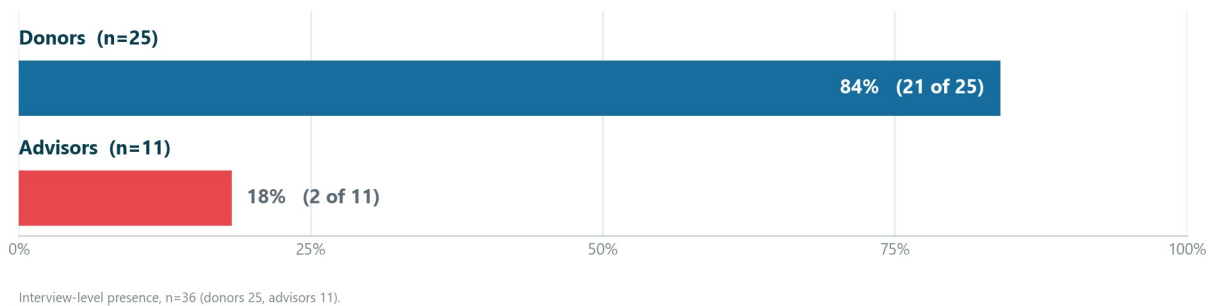


Figure 3. The self-named say-do gap: 21 of 25 donors (84%) versus 2 of 11 advisors (18%) named at least one divergence between their stated criteria and their enacted giving. The tag was applied only where the subject named the divergence themselves.

Finding 7: Character concerns veto gifts that nothing else could stop.

Gift-sizing (Finding 3) has one behavior it cannot explain. When a donor doubts a candidate's character, the response is not a smaller gift but no gift. Character concern zeroes the decision rather than shrinking it, and in every coded collision in this sample (three cases), the character floor won, including against the relationships that upend everything else. The donor of Finding 5 who declared a hosted candidate "dead to me politically" did so on firsthand conduct reports, not electoral performance (Interview 22). Another donor's exception, in thirty years of a meeting-means-giving practice, was a character refusal, "I decided I needed to take a shower instead of write a check. I just didn't like him from the get-go and thought he was a phony. It's the only time I ever had that reaction" (Interview 11). The floor is asymmetric. Disliking a candidate vetoes an otherwise attractive gift, "if it's like racist, sexist comments, I wouldn't support — I would be very unlikely to support that candidate. If it's other flaws, I would probably go for the competitive race" (Interview 16). But liking a candidate does not fund an otherwise unattractive race, "I like [a safe-seat incumbent]; I don't give her money because she's going to win with or without my money" (Interview 22). Among the evaluation criteria donors state, character was also the one most often behind an actual refusal of a named opportunity. In practice, donors talk in viability terms but refuse on character grounds.

Finding 8: Donors come in four types, and the professionals are the other side of the market.

The patterns above do not fall uniformly across the sample. Donor profiles cluster into four types (Figure 4). **Strategists** (4 of 25) research firsthand, think in long horizons and

marginal dollars, and largely refuse delegation. **Planners** (10 of 25) run on standing rules and budgets, absorb uncertainty through gift-sizing, and keep their exceptions contained. **Loyalists** (7 of 25) give through relationships, reciprocity, and person-to-person trust. **Responders** (4 of 25) are ask-driven and reactive and say so.

The types matter because they change what the findings mean in practice. Delegation is the clearest example. A Strategist refuses it and treats it as skeptical. A Planner treats it as confidence in a vetted system. A Loyalist treats it as trust in a particular person. A Responder treats it as relief from the evaluative work. The say-do gap follows the same contours: it concentrates among Loyalists and the leakier Planners, and it is thinnest among Strategists. Put simply, the donors who delegate least are the ones whose stated strategies most closely match their actual giving.

The four donor types

One square per donor (n = 25), filled from the top left.



Dominant tendency per donor; most donors blend elements of more than one type.

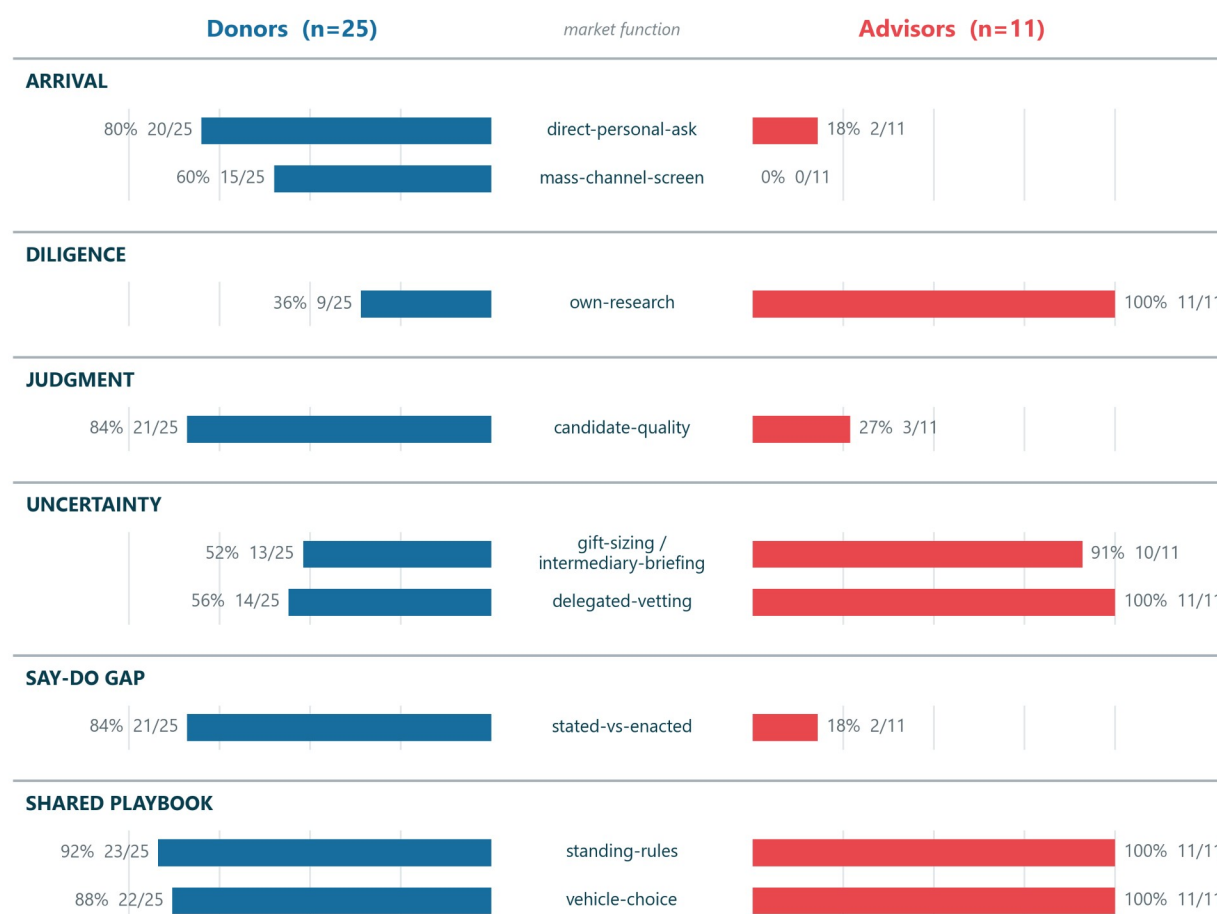
Figure 4. The four donor types (n=25): Strategists (4), Planners (10), Loyalists (7), Responders (4). Assigned from each donor's dominant coded profile; hybrids flagged in the underlying analysis.

The eleven professionals are not simply better-informed donors, they are the supply side of the market whose demand side the donors constitute, and the two registers are near mirror images (Figure 5). Where donors receive asks (80% either traced a gift to a direct personal ask or named a valued race that went unfunded for lack of one; 60% screen out mass channels wholesale), advisors source opportunities. Where donor diligence is a minority practice (36%), it is the universal advisor posture (11 of 11). Where donors volunteer their exceptions (84%), advisors almost never narrate a say-do gap of their own

(2 of 11). They can spot it in their clients though. And where donors cope with uncertainty, advisors sell certainty. Nearly every advisor interviewed produces briefing products (10 of 11), and every one supplies the delegated vetting that the donors of Finding 2 consume. The advisors can name what they are actually selling. One, who leads a donor alliance, described the advisory work as camaraderie and continuity, "It allows donors to not feel alone, but also feeling like they're not just... throwing money into the wind" (Advisor interview 24). Another deflates the fear the whole market runs on, "they're so worried that they're going to make a wrong decision. And I say, there's not really a wrong decision" (Advisor interview 29). A third curates the impact story donors cannot see for themselves, "I have to... find the articles that show that through-line of — your donation helped this happen... I never say your donation made it happen... And it makes them feel good" (Advisor interview 32).

Standing rules and vehicle-type thinking are the shared playbook, near-universal on both sides of the market. Nearly everything else about the two populations diverges. Eleven practitioners of one profession using the same methods. Giving is a private practice that scatters twenty-five individuals doing it in patterned but genuinely different ways. The four types are the structure inside the scatter, and the point where delegation meets supply is where an intermediary organization can leverage its insights.

Two sides of the same market



Interview-level presence, n=36. Each row pairs the donor-side and advisor-side code for the same market function.

Figure 5. Two sides of the same market: donors (demand side) and advisors (supply side) across six functions, with the delegation hinge where intermediaries transact.

A note on what these counts can and cannot say. All counts are interview-level presence over small groups (25 donors, 11 advisors). They support comparison and ranking, not population estimates, and the advisor column reaches unanimity far more easily than the donor column. One further caution attaches to the advisor perfect scores. Advisors' uniformly professional accounts may partly reflect professional self-presentation, the same force that plausibly keeps advisors from reporting say-do gaps of their own.

Recommendations for MRNC

The findings describe a specific environment. Donors manage a flood of appeals they mostly screen out and give almost exclusively through people and channels they trust;

standing rules do most of the sorting; judgment is delegated where trust exists; and the thing donors most want to know, whether their money worked, is named by donors themselves as unknowable. The recommendations taken together describe a strategic posture. MRNC's opportunity is not to out-shout the field but to become the organization that resolves the uncertainty.

1. Be the filter donors already trust. The most consistent pairing in the data is that a majority of donors describe handing their evaluative work to a trusted intermediary, and every advisor interviewed describes supplying exactly that service. This is the market MRNC already sits in. The recommendation is to treat the filtering and vetting role not as a byproduct of fundraising but as the product itself. Hold curated briefings, publish slates with the reasoning visible, and build a vetting process donors can understand. One caveat is that because of the researcher's position in this network, the warmest delegation evidence comes from donors describing organizations connected to the researcher. MRNC should validate demand with donors outside its existing orbit before scaling this recommendation.

2. Serve both donors who trust systems and donors who trust people. The interviews suggest that delegating donors split into two kinds. There are those who trust organizations, wanting transparency and criteria with the reasoning attached, and those who trust individuals, wanting a known person whose word carries weight. If the split holds up, one offering will not serve both. For the first group, MRNC should publish its logic and make its criteria inspectable by donors. For the second, it should invest and build up a small number of credible, durable relationships between donors and the people who brief them. It is best to treat the split as something worth testing directly with donors before committing substantial resources to the effort. The same finding carries a warning that there are a minority of donors, including some of the most sophisticated, who refuse delegation entirely and read intermediary offers as a bid for control. Any offering should be framed as leverage the donor commands, not judgment that replaces theirs.

3. Show donors what their money did. The most-wanted, least-available information in the sample is whether the money worked. Donors do not expect certainty. The interviews show them settling for signals as thin as a thank-you note or a candidate's hustle. That is a low bar, and it is the field's largest open flank. An organization that reports back, plainly stating what was funded, what it did, and what changed, including when the honest answer is "we can't tell yet," supplies the closest available substitute for the information donors have stopped asking for. This also answers the accountability complaint professional

advisors make about the field, that political fundraising asks for money on narrative and returns silence.

4. Show donors where their dollars matter. Showing donors what their money did after an election closes the loop after a gift. Demonstrating why their dollars matter can be just as critical. The most widely shared evaluation rule in these interviews is not "can this candidate win?" but "does my gift matter?" Four of five donors steer money toward places where dollars are scarce and away from races already saturated with cash. They enforce the rule by sitting races out. Donors in this study declined marquee races they believed in because a check disappears at that scale. One donor volunteered that a five-figure gift to a well-funded statewide fund should have gone to North Carolina down-ballot races where the money was scarce. Another routes her largest gifts to state-level infrastructure precisely because it helps every candidate in the state at once. Every ask should carry the scarcity case. Early money, down-ballot races, and shared infrastructure all pass the test these donors already run. And because donors let the amount carry their confidence, a legible scarcity case makes the best case for funds.

5. Steward relationships that hold the money. Donor departures in this study followed leadership changes, board drift, unacknowledged gifts, and conduct problems. Never did it occur because of lost electoral races. Donors will fund losing races for years. They will not stay through the loss of the person or the courtesy that anchored the relationship. Three strategies are directly actionable. First, acknowledgment discipline is crucial. Its absence has been stated as a reason a donor stopped giving. Second, leadership-transition planning that treats donor relationships as institutional assets to be handed over deliberately, not personal assets that walk out the door. Third, visible board and staff coherence. Donors read organizational conduct as a stand-in for the effectiveness they cannot otherwise observe. In every exit narrated in this sample, these were the stated reasons donors left.

6. Deliver the asks that matter through voices donors already trust. In numerous interviews, there were races donors believed in but left unfunded because nobody they trusted asked for a gift. One active donor, reviewing why he funded two at-risk incumbents but not a third, pointed first to the missing ask, "I don't know why I didn't give [to the third]. I think no one asked me, honestly... I thought it was manufactured, that it was going to be as close as it was. And I was wrong" (Interview 18). Another put the missing ask plainly, "Well, is anybody asking? If so, who is it?... It doesn't mean that I'm going to support every race, you know, just of my own accord" (Interview 17). In this sample, gifts arrived through direct personal asks and almost never through mass channels (emails, texts, direct

mail). Donors in this study did not fund priorities on merit alone. If no one they trusted asked for a gift, the check was never sent. MRNC must close this gap. It needs to map which donors have a trusted channel to the organization, and route priority asks through named, known relationships rather than general appeals. The ask that never came is arguably the cheapest money to recover, because the donor is already persuaded.

These six recommendations form one program and are strongest adopted together.

Conclusion

This project set out to learn how high-net-worth donors evaluate political giving under uncertainty. The honest answer from thirty-six interviews is that mostly they do not evaluate in the way the concept implies. They manage the lack of information. The information a donor would need is not available in advance and no amount of appeal volume supplies it. Instead, donors decide in advance, through standing rules that settle most asks before a decision is made. They hand judgment to people and institutions they trust and they let the size of the check carry the uncertainty. The rules are real. Yet, they bend in one predictable direction in favor of relationships. Donors know all of this about themselves and name it. The gap between their stated criteria and their actual giving is the most consistently self-reported pattern in these interviews, and a conservatively measured one.

For MRNC, the strategic meaning is direct. In a landscape of more money and less visibility, donors are searching for trust and for the first organization willing to show them what their money did. The organizations that earn lasting major donor support, if these donors are any indication, will be the ones that do the work of a qualified and trusted intermediary. That means filtering, vetting, reporting back, and stewarding the relationships that are critical to the longevity of any organization.

Appendices and Supporting Materials

AI and Technology Use Statement. The research question, capstone structure, interview protocols, strategic direction, and final judgments in this report are the author's own. AI and third-party services were used under the author's direction and review. Interview transcription used Granola, an enterprise transcription service operating under SOC 2 guidelines. With the consultation of the author's faculty advisor and graduate program director, AI tools (Claude Code, by Anthropic) were used, on anonymized transcripts held entirely offline, to draft and apply the qualitative codebook, and produce pattern analyses, all under the author's direction. The author determined priorities and retained final authority over every analytical decision. The resulting analysis was checked against a quantitative text-analysis layer (topic models and dictionary tests in R). Claude Code was also used to acquire and process public campaign finance data (FEC, NCSBE, IRS filings) and to render the report's figures to the author's specification. The author reviewed code structure and outputs. Claude conversations were used as a sounding board to brainstorm, critique, and propose alternative section structures. Google Gemini was used to find contemporary news articles. Zotero was used to create and format citations.

Table A1. Active campaign committees in North Carolina by election cycle, 2001–2024
(cross-referenced from the Landscape section)

Cycle	Candidate	PAC	Party	Other	Total	Committees Raising Original Money
2001–02	799	332	253	57	1,441	1,165
2003–04	706	385	251	24	1,366	1,038
2005–06	714	398	271	15	1,398	1,060
2007–08	758	407	298	31	1,494	1,110
2009–10	867	281	237	15	1,400	1,073
2011–12	878	269	228	34	1,409	1,088
2013–14	734	287	257	21	1,299	975
2015–16	946	360	333	44	1,683	1,305

Cycle	Candidate	PAC	Party	Other	Total	Committees Raising Original Money
2017–18	1,423	451	424	92	2,390	1,915
2019–20	1,516	476	462	122	2,576	1,948
2021–22	1,756	398	460	102	2,716	2,151
2023–24	1,518	384	420	81	2,403	1,868

A committee is active in a cycle if it recorded at least one receipt or expenditure in NC State Board of Elections disclosure data. The final column counts committees raising new money from original sources (excluding transfers and loans), the robustness check referenced in the figure footnote. It averages about 77% of the active count with the same trajectory.

Table A2. Active federal campaign committees by election cycle, 2001–2024 (cross-referenced from the Landscape section)

Cycle	Candidate	PAC	Party	Other	Total
2001–02	2,179	3,961	404	102	6,646
2003–04	2,159	4,266	415	113	6,953
2005–06	2,167	4,440	423	154	7,184
2007–08	2,509	4,608	415	346	7,878
2009–10	3,074	4,843	402	324	8,643
2011–12	3,137	5,342	423	345	9,247
2013–14	2,817	5,438	408	341	9,004
2015–16	2,731	5,762	424	450	9,367
2017–18	3,550	6,013	431	631	10,625
2019–20	3,799	6,492	457	769	11,517
2021–22	3,894	6,812	420	839	11,965
2023–24	3,430	7,131	443	948	11,952

A committee is active in a cycle if it reported at least one receipt or disbursement to the FEC. Candidate counts for 2001–06 are candidate-level (FEC all-candidates summary files) and understate committee-level counts by about 6%. Later cycles use FEC bulk committee summary files. Joint fundraising committees are counted in Other. See the methods note for bucket definitions and sources. Author's analysis of FEC bulk and API data.

Table B1. Interview Questions for High-Net-Worth Individual Interview (cross-referenced from the Research and Analysis Plan)

Category	Question
Origin Story	Tell me how you came to political giving in the first place.
Information Sources	When you think about the universe of political opportunities you could fund, how do you find out about what is out there?
Evaluation Criteria	Once an opportunity is in front of you, how do you decide whether to fund it?
Role of Relationships	Who do you actually consult before significant political decisions?
Allocation Logic	Step back and look at your political giving as a whole. How do you think about the mix? Do you think across vehicle types (campaigns, PACs, 501(c)(4)s, 501(c)(3)s) as one strategy or in separate buckets?
Cross-Axes Question	I'd like to walk through one specific decision with you. Think of a political gift from the last 18 months that you'd most want to get right; the one where the stakes felt highest. You don't have to tell me which one it is. Got it in mind? Without naming it if you'd rather not, walk me through how you got there, when you first heard about it, who you talked to, and what you looked at before deciding.
Information Asymmetry	Stepping back, when you give, what's something you wish you could see or know but can't?
Information Asymmetry	Has the broader environment, the post-Citizens United landscape or the current climate, changed how much or how you give?
Information Asymmetry	Given all we've discussed around decision-making, how does all this compare against how you think about charitable giving?

Additional probe questions were slated below each main question and were discretionarily used based on timing.

Table B2. Interview Questions for Donor Advisor Interview *(cross-referenced from the Research and Analysis Plan)*

Category	Question
Origin Story	Tell me about your advisory practice. How would you describe what you do for clients?
Information Sources	Where do your clients typically hear about political opportunities?
Evaluation Criteria	What criteria do you apply when evaluating a political opportunity for a client?
Role of Relationship	Where do you sit in the client's decision-making? Who else is in the room?
Allocation Logic	How do you think about portfolio construction across vehicles for political work?
Cross Axes	Describe a recent client decision that surprised you. It does not have to be good or bad. Just one where the outcome wasn't what you would have predicted.
Synthesis	How do you and your clients define and measure success for political work?
Synthesis	Where does client behavior diverge most from how they handle sophisticated charitable giving?
Synthesis	What do you think most donors get wrong about political giving?

Additional probe questions were slated below each main question and were discretionarily used based on timing.

Appendix C. The Codebook

The coding instrument comprises 22 codes: 20 axis codes organized into four families (Information Sources, Evaluation Criteria, Allocation Logic, and Relationships), plus two cross-cutting tags that may co-occur with any axis code.

Axis 1: Information Sources

How opportunity information reaches the subject.

Code	Definition	Counted when
Direct personal ask (1.1)	A giving opportunity reaches the donor through a direct, person-specific ask (a call, meeting, referral, or event invitation) from a candidate or someone the donor knows.	A specific gift traces to a personal or trusted-venue ask, or a race the donor valued goes unfunded because no ask ever came.
Mass-channel screening (1.2)	Impersonal high-volume solicitation (texts, cold calls, direct mail, bulk email) is screened out wholesale by standing habit or rule, without per-opportunity evaluation.	Blocking, unsubscribing, discarding unread, or scripted refusal keyed to the channel itself, including filtering described as automatic.
Intermediary briefing (1.3)	Donor alliances, collaboratives, advisory organizations, and subscription political communities supply the donor's map of races and groups through briefing calls, slates, targeting lists, showcases, and curated candidate material.	Donor credits organizational briefings or slates for knowing which races matter; an advisor produces such material; a donor reviews curated material while judging independently.
Peer intelligence (1.4)	Spouses, siblings, friends, mentors, and well-connected acquaintances supply specific candidate and race intelligence that the donor does not gather personally.	A peer surfaces candidates or supplies race assessments used as input to a decision the donor still makes themselves.

Axis 2: Evaluation Criteria

How an opportunity is judged once visible.

Code	Definition	Counted when
Viability screen (2.1)	A stated threshold requirement that a race be both winnable and genuinely in doubt; safe wins and sure losses alike are screened out.	Win-chance, closeness, or contestedness voiced as a gate; closer races drawing larger gifts; enacted refusals of safe or

Code	Definition	Counted when
		hopeless races.
Marginal-dollar test (2.2)	The opportunity is judged by whether this donor's specific dollars would be consequential at the margin; money goes where it is scarce and is withheld from saturated races, well-funded recipients, and scales where the check cannot matter.	Saturation or recipient-already-well-funded reasoning; preferring early-stage or down-ballot gifts for leverage; feeling one's giving tier pointless at large scales.
Candidate quality (2.3)	The individual candidate is judged as a person (competence, character, temperament, work ethic, authenticity), with conduct floors that can veto an otherwise attractive race; the floor is asymmetric (dislike vetoes more readily than liking funds).	Person-level assessment of a candidate, including reading pitch manner as evidence of effort; character or conduct disqualifiers overriding strategic screens.
Own research (2.4)	The subject evaluates through self-gathered evidence (reading routines, public records, scorecards, spreadsheets, formal metrics) rather than through asks, peers, or delegation.	A personal research routine or documentable diligence described for a specific decision; advisors' first-person interrogation of proposals on clients' behalf.
Unknowables and proxies (2.5)	The information subjects most need (spending effectiveness, true marginal need, candidate effort and follow-through, hidden scandal, outcome certainty) is named as structurally unobtainable, and observable proxies stand in for it.	A wished-for but unverifiable datum is named; explicit proxy use; giving suppressed or misdirected by the gap; regret over unknowable information.

Axis 3: Allocation Logic

How money is distributed across races, levels, vehicles, and time.

Code	Definition	Counted when
Standing rules (3.1)	Self-authored categorical rules allocate in advance of any particular ask (geographic	A geographic, party, or tier rule stated or applied; budget and

Code	Definition	Counted when
	boundaries, party defaults, office-level tiers, budgets, pacing, stated single-objective screens), functioning as triage against ask volume and as polite refusal scripts.	timing architecture; a stated cycle objective screening out non-fitting asks; narrated rule exceptions.
Gift sizing (3.2)	The operative allocation move is the amount: token gifts for obligation and long shots, caps for safe winners, substantial money for priorities; lower confidence shrinks the gift rather than producing refusal or more research.	Amount explicitly graded to confidence, need, closeness, or obligation; giving less when knowing less; token checks containing relationship pressure.
Vehicle choice (3.3)	The legal-vehicle class (direct-to-candidate, party committee, PAC, nonprofit, victory fund, impact investment) is itself treated as a reason to give, refuse, or route, whether as categorical distrust, professed unfamiliarity, or deliberate multi-entity design.	Standing vehicle-class refusals; preferring the candidate as recipient; vehicle confusion with concrete routing consequences; multi-vehicle design; limit-driven rerouting.
Disclosure management (3.4)	Whether the donor's name will be publicly attached (to regulators, business counterparties, communities, coverage, or feared persons, including personal-safety threats) structures the gift before evaluation, managed audience by audience through vehicles, thresholds, check-splitting, suppression, or deliberately sought visibility.	Anonymity-seeking routing; checks kept under thresholds or split; giving suppressed by exposure or safety fear; deliberate display; advisors treating disclosure as an intake parameter.
Time horizon (3.5)	Gifts are allocated against an explicit time horizon (strictly cycle-bounded win-seeking at one pole, multi-cycle infrastructure and bench-building at the other), with the long pole tolerating near-term losses and redefining success beyond the immediate race.	Long-game rationales for funding expected losers or uncompetitive places; success defined beyond the next election; the explicit cycle-bounded counter-position.

Axis 4: Relationships

Who influences the decision, and how the donor's network position shapes giving.

Code	Definition	Counted when
Reciprocity debt (4.1)	An unwritten code among donor-fundraiser peers: having asked someone for money, or having been helped by them, obligates giving when they ask in return; hosting obligates giving at the level asked of others.	The exchange code voiced, or a prior exchange narrated as the driver; hosting engineered to create standing to refuse; obligations voided by a disrespectful ask.
Relationship override (4.2)	When the donor's stated criteria and a relationship point in different directions, the relationship frequently governs, and the conflict is typically managed by shrinking the gift to a token rather than refusing.	Gifts the donor concedes their own analysis would not fund, carried by the asker or host; rules bent for friends; token containment and its failures.
Delegated vetting (4.3)	The donor hands the core evaluative work (which races matter, who is viable, where money is needed) to a trusted intermediary organization or specific validator, treating that judgment as a substitute for their own.	Checks written against another's targeting; reliance on an intermediary's completed research; lump-sum handoffs; a trusted individual's word unlocking or zeroing a gift; refusals to delegate.
Household governance (4.4)	Political giving is governed inside the household: spouses and partners function as co-deciders through informal dollar thresholds, divisions of labor, or standing agreements, or as a constraint negotiated around.	Consultation thresholds; joint planning rituals; either-spouse-sufficient rules; spousal opposition capping amounts; governance by absence.
Person trust (4.5)	Trust attaches to specific people rather than institutions: confidence in who leads opens and sustains funding, and leadership turnover, misconduct, or perceived disrespect ruptures it; exits follow organizational failure signals more than electoral losses.	Giving or continuing because of trust in specific leaders; withdrawal traced to leadership change, conduct, or strategy drift; trusted people re-opening refused vehicles.

Code	Definition	Counted when
Donor as hub (4.6)	The donor operates as a hub, not just a node: hosting, validating candidates for peers, and mobilizing other donors is part of the giving decision, and some gifts are made to build or maintain the donor's own network and credibility as an asker.	Hosting as network-position strategy; serving as other donors' validator; gifts framed, sized, or displayed as network-building or credibility maintenance.

Cross-cutting tags

May co-occur with any axis code; at most two tags per segment.

Code	Definition	Counted when
Negative case (T1)	The segment records a specific enacted negative case: an opportunity, recipient, or relationship declined, exited, defunded, or deliberately sat out, including an actual non-gift in a race the donor says mattered, where no ask ever arrived.	A specific non-gift, cutoff, exit, suspension, or walk-away is described, always tagged alongside the axis code carrying the refusal logic.
Stated vs. enacted (T2)	The segment shows a self-named divergence between the subject's stated rule, criterion, or self-description and their reported behavior, with both poles present in the transcript.	Mid-sentence reversals; deny-then-describe sequences; self-cataloged exceptions; acknowledged discipline failures, tagged alongside the axis code whose rule is breached.

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